

1855-56

MARCH 1855

Thousands of Missourians vote fraudulently in elections for the Kansas territorial legislature, ensuring a pro-slavery majority. The result is recognized by the Federal governor of the territory.

JULY 1855

The pro-slavery Kansas legislature begins to enact measures to protect slavery in the territory.

OCTOBER 1855

Free-Soilers in Kansas set up their own legislature and adopt a constitution outlawing enslavement. Anti-slavery settlers are sent guns hidden in boxes marked "Bibles." These become known as "Beecher's Bibles."



.52 caliber Sharps carbine, popularly known as the "Beecher's Bible"

MAY 21 1856

In ongoing violence between pro- and anti-slavery factions in Kansas, pro-slavery men "sack" the town of Lawrence. A few days later, abolitionist John Brown carries out a retaliatory attack at Pottawatomie Creek.